

☒ RARE OR UNUSUAL RECORD☐ NEW STATE RECORD☒ ACCEPTED☐ REJECTED

23-76-62

04/26/76

Species: LITTLE GULL
(Vernacular Name)LARUS MINUTUS
(Scientific Name-use binomial)Date(s): 22-27 MAY, 1976 Time Bird Seen: 3:30 PM (5/22) to 2:15 PM (5/22)
Locality: UNION RESERVOIR TOTAL TIME OBSERVED: ABOUT 12 HRS.
Nearest Town: LONGMONT County: WELD

Other observers who independently identified this bird:

NAME	ADDRESS	TELEPHONE
<u>MICHAEL MULLTON</u>	<u>1328 So. COFFMAN LONGMONT, COLO.</u>	<u>772-0283</u>
<u>JUDD SUNDINE</u>	<u>4305 EA. FLORIDA DENVER, COLO.</u>	<u>756-1116</u>
<u>BRUCE WEBB</u>	<u>21 CHAUTAUQUA BOULDER, COLO.</u>	<u>447-2614</u>

Optical Equipment: 7x35 BINOCULARS; 20-45x60 TELESCOPEIf photographed, type of equipment used: 35MM W/ 400MM TELEPHOTOLight Conditions: POOR TO EXCELLENTDistance from bird (how measured): AS CLOSE AS 50 FT. (CAMERA LENS RANGEFINDER)Number of Birds Seen: 1 Sex: _____ Plumage: JUVENAL

Describe the bird's overall behavior and demeanor:

BIRD WAS RATHER SHY AND QUITE ALERT MOST OF THE OBSERVATION PERIOD. IT DID NOT SEEM ENTIRELY HEALTHY BUT THIS MAY BE A FUNCTION OF FATIGUE AND NERVOUSNESS ON ITS PART. WHEN LAST SEEN IT FLEW AWAY OF ITS OWN ACCORD. WHILE UNDER OBSERVATION IT STOOD MUCH, FLEW SOME AND SWAM VERY LITTLE. IT SEEMED TO FEED ACTIVELY AND OCCASIONALLY PICKED UP TWIGS AND/OR SHORELINE TRASH, WHICH IT PURPOSEFULLY MOVED TO OTHER LOCATIONS. IT FLEW BEAUTIFULLY, LOW TO THE WATER, MUCH LIKE A TERN.

Describe in great detail the bird's size, overall shape, plumage and color-pattern.Include details on shape of bill, wings and tail. Give particular emphasis to the marks you used to identify the bird. Reference to its resemblance in field guide descriptions is not enough. Describe what you actually saw in the field:

SIZE - CONSIDERABLY SMALLER THAN BONAPARTE'S AND FRANKLIN'S GULLS IN ITS VICINITY. ITS LENGTH WAS ABOUT THAT OF THE NEARBY BLACK TERNS, THOUGH ITS BULK WAS GREATER.

SHAPE - LIKE A MINIATURE FRANKLIN'S GULL

BILL - RATHER SMALL COMPARED TO PROPORTIONS OF BILLS IN OTHER GULLS, BLACK

LEGS AND FEET - RED

HEAD - WHITE WITH GRAY CAP AND DARK GRAY ROUND SPOT BEHIND EYE

THROAT, NAPE, BREAST, BELLY, FLANKS, UNDERTAIL COVERTS, RUMP AND TAIL - SNOWY WHITE; TAIL WITH SQUARED TIP AND BLACK TERMINAL BAND (NARROW).

MANTLE - SILVERY GRAY.

UNDERSIDE OF WING - VERY PALE GRAY, ONLY SLIGHTLY DARKER THAN BELLY AND UNIFORM IN SHADE

UPPERSIDE OF WING - ~~DARK GRAY~~ MEDIUM GRAY WITH WHITE BORDER TO SECONDARIES AND INNER PRIMARIES (BORDER VERY NARROW, BUT QUITE APPARENT IN FLIGHT). DARKER BLACKISH-GRAY STRIPE FROM POSTERIOR BASE OF WING TO WRIST, JOINED WITH DARK OUTER PRIMARIES FORMED A ZIG-ZAG PATTERN, DISCERNIBLE AT CLOSE RANGE IN GOOD LIGHT. (OVER)

WING SHAPE - FAIRLY LONG AND ROUNDED. AT REST, THE WINGS

Describe the bird's song or call, if heard, including method of delivery, i.e., from perch, in flight, etc: CALL NOT HEARD

Describe the habitat in which you observed this bird:

MOSTLY ON SANDY SHORLINE OF PLAINS RESERVOIR, SOMETIMES SEEN IN ALFALFA FIELDS WITH FRANKLIN'S GULLS.

How were similarly appearing species eliminated?

TOLD FROM ALL GULLS BY SIZE (SIDE-BY-SIDE COMPARISONS WITH FRANKLIN'S AND BONAPARTE'S GULLS), AND BY THESE PLUMAGE DETAILS FROM BLACK-LEGGED KITTIWAKE BY BLACK NAPE LINE AND BLACK LEGS OF THAT SPECIES' JUVENAL PLUMAGE

FROM JUVENAL BONAPARTE'S BY TOTAL LACK OF WHITE IN PRIMARIES AND WHITE NAPE, AND DISTINCTLY DARK CAP. THIS BIRD WAS SEEN WITH IMMATURE BONAPARTE'S GULLS AND THE CROWN-NAPE AND CROWN-SIDE OF HEAD CONTRAST WAS MUCH GREATER IN IT THAN IN THE BONAPARTE'S. FOLDED WING OF THIS GULL WAS VERY DARK, CONTRASTING SHARPLY WITH THE MANTLE WHEREAS THE WING-MANTLE CONTRAST IN THE IMMATURE BONAPARTE'S IS HARDLY NOTICEABLE.

Prior experience with this and similarly appearing species:

I HAD NEVER OBSERVED THE LITTLE GULL IN ANY PLUMAGE, BUT AM REASONABLY FAMILIAR WITH FRANKLIN'S AND BONAPARTE'S GULLS.

Books, illustrations and advice consulted and how did these influence this documentation?

THE IDENTIFICATION WAS CONFIRMED BY MICHAEL MOULTON, JUDD SUNDINE, BRUCE WEBB AND JEANNE CONRY. THE FIELD GUIDES TO WHICH I TURNED TO CONFIRM MY IDENTIFICATION DID NOT ACCURATELY ACCOUNT THIS PLUMAGE, AND THEREFORE PLAYED NO PART IN THIS REPORT

This report was written from notes made during X after observation; from memory

PRINT NAME: PETER J. MOULTON SIGNATURE: Peter J. Moulton DATE: 28 May, 1976

Street Address: 1528 So. COFFMAN #3 Town and State: LONGMONT, Colo. ZIP: 80501

Return to: JACK REDDALL - 1450 South Alton Street, Englewood, Colorado 80110

Species: LITTLE GULL

Larus minutus

(Vernacular Name)

(Scientific Name-use binomial)

Date(s): May 23, 1976

Time Bird Seen: 1:15 P.M.

to 1:30 P.M.-MDT

Locality: Union Reservoir

Nearest Town: Longmont

County: Weld

Other observers who independently identified this bird:

NAME ADDRESS TELEPHONE
 Bruce Webb, Jeanne Conry, Michael Moulton, Peter Moulton, Dave Griffiths, Steve Larson
 and a multitude of other observers.

Optical Equipment: 10X50 Bushnell Binoculars; 15X-60X Zoom Telescope

If photographed, type of equipment used:

Light Conditions: Overcast with light rain showers and drizzle.

Distance from bird (how measured): 150 feet (estimated).

Number of Birds Seen: One Sex: Unknown Plumage: Immature (second summer-?)

Describe the bird's overall behavior and demeanor:

First noticed as it rested in shallow water with six Ring-billed Gulls. When attempts to approach the bird to photograph it frightened it, the bird took to the air, circled around a couple of times and landed again on a mud flat out of view behind the cattails. Its flight was sustained with very rapid (almost tern-like) wing beats.

Describe in great detail the bird's size, overall shape, plumage and color-pattern. Include details on shape of bill, wings and tail. Give particular emphasis to the marks you used to identify the bird. Reference to its resemblance in field guide descriptions is not enough. Describe what you actually saw in the field:

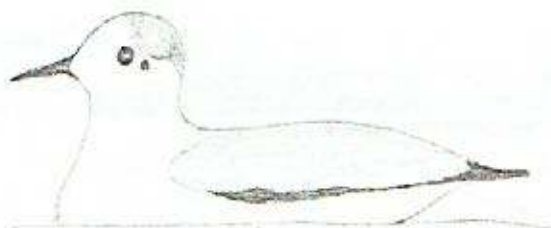
An extremely small gull which was readily noticeable as it sat next to the six Ring-billed Gulls. Bill, straight, black. Eye, dark. Forehead, chin, throat and remainder of under parts, white. Conspicuous black dot behind eye. Top of head and nape, grayish-brown. Back, slaty-gray. Rump, white. Tail, rounded, white on upper surface with narrow black band near tip. Under surface of tail, white with black terminal band also. Wings, short, rounded at tip. Upper surface of wings mostly dark with black diagonal band (did not contrast in my mind as greatly as depicted in the Field Guides). Under surface of wing, whitish in wing linings becoming dark gray in the tips of the primaries.



UPPER TAIL



UPPER WING SURFACE



APPEARANCE OF BIRD AS IT RESTED ON WATER

(OVER)

Describe the bird's song or call, if heard, including method of delivery, i.e., from perch, in flight, etc:

The bird was silent during period of observation.

Describe the habitat in which you observed this bird:

Large fresh water reservoir bordered with sparse cattail marshes and surrounded mainly with farmlands.

How were similarly appearing species eliminated?

Bonaparte's Gull (immature): Obviously larger. Lacks dark upper wing surface marked with black diagonal band. Immature has white head with black ear spot but lacks the grayish-brown area on the crown and nape.

Black-headed Gull (immature): Larger still. Same sequence of plumages as immature Bonaparte's Gull.

Franklin's Gull and Laughing Gull (immature): Obviously larger. Both display dark upper wing surfaces but lack the black diagonal band. Tail terminal band much broader.

Black-legged Kittiwake (immature): Also has wing band, but surface of upper wing much lighter. Also, a much larger bird.

Prior experience with this and similarly appearing species:

Have seen all the "black-headed" gulls in North America although this is the first time I have seen an immature Little Gull. I have seen one Black-headed Gull which was an adult in winter plumage (Long Island, New York). This is the third time I have seen a Little Gull in Colorado - an adult in winter plumage at Union Reservoir in November of 1974 and an adult in breeding plumage at Jumbo Reservoir in May of 1976.

Books, illustrations and advice consulted and how did these influence this documentation?

Standard Field Guides supported observation.

This report was written from notes made during x after x observation; from memory

PRINT NAME: JACK REDDALL SIGNATURE: *Jack Reddall* DATE: June 2, 1976
Street Address: 4450 South Alton Street Town and State: Englewood, Colorado ZIP: 80111

Return to: JACK REDDALL - 4450 South Alton Street, Englewood, Colorado 80110

Species: Little Gull Larus minutus
 (Vernacular Name) (Scientific Name-use binomial)

Date(s): 27 May 1976 Time Bird Seen: 1315 to 1345

Locality: Union Reservoir

Nearest Town: Longmont County: Weld

Other observers who independently identified this bird:

NAME	ADDRESS	TELEPHONE
Mike and Pete Moulton	Jack Reddall	
Bruce Webb	Barry Knapp	
Steve Larson	Tim Gates	

Optical Equipment: 10 X 50 binoculars, 15-60 X B&L Zoom telescope

If photographed, type of equipment used: _____

Light Conditions: Sunny, with sun coming at right angles from observer.

Distance from bird (how measured): Minimum estimated distance-30 feet(Maximum-70 ft.)

Number of Birds Seen: 1 Sex: ? Plumage: 1st-year immature molting into adult

Describe the bird's overall behavior and demeanor:

When first found, the bird was sitting, standing and preening on the muddy beach in company with 1 Ring-billed Gull, 1 Franklin's Gull and 3 Forster's Terns. As we approached close, all the other bird flew one by one until only the Little Gull remained. Finally, it too flew, flew down the shoreline and landed again. This procedure was repeated several times to allow us a close examination of the bird sitting and in flight.

Describe in great detail the bird's size, overall shape, plumage and color-pattern. Include details on shape of bill, wings and tail. Give particular emphasis to the marks you used to identify the bird. Reference to its resemblance in field guide descriptions is not enough. Describe what you actually saw in the field:

A very small gull, distinctly smaller than the other birds(even the terns). Head rather small and delicate, a tiny black bill, a fairly short, square tail and fairly short legs(black). Head white with a diffuse gray crown patch(continuous with gray nape and back), small black cheek spot. Entire underparts, rump and tail white. Upperwing pattern: mostly dark blackish-brown, with some gray on the trailing edge of the wing and around the shoulder. Tail white with a moderately broad black terminal band. Underwing pattern: grayish-white. Very tern-like flight.

Describe the bird's song or call, if heard, including method of delivery, i.e., from perch, in flight, etc:

None heard.

Describe the habitat in which you observed this bird:

Medium-sized reservoir in agricultural country.

How were similarly appearing species eliminated?

Tiny size and tern-like flight eliminated all other species. The only gull that could possibly approach it in size and plumage would be Bonaparte's, but in all plumages it has white primaries, also has a thinner tail band.

Prior experience with this and similarly appearing species:

I have seen all of the common Colorado gulls (Herring, California, Ring-billed, Franklin's and Bonaparte's) many times. I have seen the Little Gull only once before, an adult in winter plumage at Union Reservoir from 2-9 November 1974.

Books, illustrations and advice consulted and how did these influence this documentation?

Standard field guides consulted, but not usable since the intermediate plumage this bird was in is not depicted.

This report was written from notes made during X after observation; from memory

PRINT NAME: Robert Andrews SIGNATURE: Robert Andrews DATE: June 16, 1976

Street Address: 1390 So Ivy Way Town and State: Denver, Co. 80224 ZIP:

Return to: JACK REDDALL - 4450 South Alton Street, Englewood, Colorado 80110